How Much Do You Know About Dad's Legal Papers?

A twelve-question check for families planning ahead. At the end: what you know, what's still unclear, and what to ask.

Answer yes, no or not sure. This checks how complete your picture is. It doesn't measure Dad or his papers, and nothing here means a document is missing, wrong or out of date.

1. Have you seen Dad's will yourself, or a copy of it, as opposed to hearing about it?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

2. Have you seen his financial power of attorney, the signed document itself?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

3. Do you know who it names to make financial decisions, from the page and not from memory?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

4. Have you seen his healthcare decision-making documents or advance healthcare directive, and do you know who they name?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

5. Do you know whether Dad has ever signed a trust?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

6. Do you know where the deed to his home and his other property documents are kept?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

7. Do you know how his major assets are titled, and who is named on the beneficiary forms?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

8. Do you know when each document was signed, from the date on it?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

9. Have you heard from Dad, in his own words, who he'd want helping with money matters and with healthcare decisions?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

10. Do the family members Dad would choose know where the signed papers are kept?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

11. Have you written down which papers you couldn't find, or aren't sure exist?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

12. Have you written down the questions you'd want an elder law attorney to look at?

◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Not sure

Answer the questions above and your page builds here.

WHAT YOU KNOW

WHAT'S STILL UNCLEAR

QUESTIONS TO CLARIFY

What this doesn't do

It counts what you know, not whether Dad's papers are valid, complete or current. A low count means there are things to find out, and most of them are a conversation with Dad or a look through a folder away. Whether a document still fits is a question for an elder law attorney. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You can see which of Dad's papers you know about, which you're guessing at, and what to ask. The planning interview asks about your family's wider situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care. Keep the page you just copied beside you while you answer.

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